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# Posting on Social Media: Influences of Positive Managerial Information Disclosures on Subordinate Proactive Behaviour and Manager–Subordinate Relationship

Shengming Liu [1], Jih-Yu Mao,[2] Zhang Yue[1] and Maoyu Zhang[3]
[1]School of Management, Fudan University, Shanghai, China, [2]Nottingham University Business School China, University of Nottingham Ningbo China, Ningbo, China, and [3]Tongji University, Shanghai, China
Corresponding author: email: jim.jy.mao@nottingham.edu.cn

**Social media is an important communication medium. It enables subordinates to follow their managers' activities outside of formal work spaces. However, knowledge about the effects of managers' social media posts on subordinates is rather limited. Drawing on social information processing theory, we propose that manager positive information disclosures on social media affect subordinates' work behaviour and relationship with their manager. We distinguish manager work-related from life-related information disclosure on social media in a pilot study. Results from the main study (a multi-time survey study) suggest that manager positive work-related information disclosure on social media has a positive effect on subordinate proactive behaviour through subordinate organizational identification, and that manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media has a positive effect on manager–subordinate relationship through perceived manager friendliness. Moreover, subordinate attention to social media strengthens the positive effects of manager positive information disclosures. Study implications and limitations and future research directions are discussed.**

## Introduction

Social media is profoundly and rapidly affecting all aspects of people's work and lives (McFarland and Ployhart, 2015; Wang, Reger and Pfarrer, 2021). Although studies have attended to social media usage in work contexts (Candi *et al.*, 2018; Grégoire *et al.*, 2024), they have concentrated on social media usage by two organizational groups—organizational leaders and individual employees. For instance, research has found that social media usage by C-suite executives (e.g. CEO and CFO) affects organizational public image (Matthews *et al.*, 2022), investor engagement intention (Yue *et al.*, 2021) and corporate social performance (Zhou, Ye and Liu, 2024), and that social media usage by individual employees influences their performance (Chen and Wei, 2020), socialization (Cai *et al.*, 2020) and voice behaviours (Holland, Cooper and Hecker, 2016; also see Chu, 2020 for a meta-analytic review). However, knowledge about how lower level managers' social media posts affect subordinates is limited.

This is an important omission, as line managers, for instance, are often a bridge between organizational leaders and employees. They interact with employees frequently and supervise employee work activities and performance. As such, employees may be more acquainted with managers than organizational leaders and may attend to and be affected by managers' social media posts in different ways. As managers act as organizational agents (Eisenberger *et al.*, 2002), they may post information about work, in addition to information about their personal lives, on social media. Social information processing theory suggests that information, especially of high salience (e.g. information communicated by managers), shapes people's attributional processes, attitudes and behaviours (Salancik and Pfeffer, 1978). Based on this premise, employees seeing their manager's social media posts may construct the meaning of the posts, gauge the meaning of the posts and react to the posts. Yet, to our best knowledge,

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no research has examined the potential impacts of managers' social media posts on subordinates' work behaviours and the mechanisms through which this influence occurs.

This article investigates two kinds of manager information disclosures—*work-related* and *life-related* information disclosures—on social media. We are particularly interested in the potential positive impacts of managers' social media posts on subordinate proactive behaviour and relationship with the manager—two aspects that are highly valued at work. We focus on positive information disclosures primarily due to the individual desire for positive self-presentation on social media (Lee-Won *et al.*, 2014; Utz, 2015). We refer to positive *work-related* and *life-related* information disclosures as the presentation of positive-valence—beneficial, useful or constructive—information about work and life, respectively.

Social information processing theory suggests that individual attitudes and behaviours can be affected by the information they receive (Salancik and Pfeffer, 1978). Individuals process various information about the organization and managers and act accordingly (Ou *et al.*, 2014). We argue that manager positive *work-related* information disclosure facilitates subordinate organizational identification, which leads to subordinate proactive behaviour. We also propose that manager positive *life-related* information disclosure engenders perceived manager friendliness, leading to enhanced manager–subordinate relationship. In addition, as greater attention to information, according to social information processing theory, nurtures more cognitive processing of the information and hence stronger reactions to the information (Gurbin, 2015), we posit that greater subordinate attention to social media, which refers to subordinate awareness of the events that happen on social media (Vraga, Bode and Troller-Renfree, 2016), strengthens our proposed positive effects of managers' social media posts.

We test the hypotheses by conducting a pilot study and a main study in a Chinese context. Social media is wide spread in China. According to Statista, WeChat and Douyin, two of the most popular social media in China, have over two billion monthly active users combined. Based on data from China Internet Network Information Center, many social media users are company employees, who use social media for sharing and communicating with work colleagues (Liu *et al.*, 2015; Zhang *et al.*, 2021). Our research makes several important contributions. Firstly, we differentiate *work-* from *life-related* information disclosure on social media and operationalize them in *manager–subordinate* contexts. Secondly, we delineate two distinct mechanisms through which managers' positive work- and life-related information disclosures influence subordinate proactive behaviour and managers' relationships with subordinates, respectively. In doing so, we extend the body of research that has so far focused on the effects of C-suite executives' social media usage (Matthews *et al.*, 2022; Yue *et al.*, 2021; Zhou, Ye and Liu, 2024) and has so far only focused on either employee performance or work relationships as outcomes of social media information disclosures (Cui *et al.*, 2020; Gibson, 2018; Rothbard *et al.*, 2022; Wang, Yuan and Feng, 2022).

## Theoretical background and hypotheses

### *Information disclosure on social media*

Information disclosure refers to the proactive display of information for others' awareness (Collins and Miller, 1994). Social media allows people to disclose information to a wider range of targets in a timely manner with fewer constraints than more traditional channels (e.g. face-to-face interactions; Thomas and Akdere, 2013). People are selective in the information they disclose on social media. Many would dedicate a substantial amount of time to information sharing and acquiring on social media. Browsing others' information displays on social media may have side effects, such as experiencing anxiety and reduced well-being (Luo and Hancock, 2020), problematic sleep (Tandon *et al.*, 2020) and psychological fatigue (Li *et al.*, 2022).

Information disclosures on social media have been studied in various organizational settings, such as human resource management (McFarland and Ployhart, 2015), corporate social responsibility (Zhou, Ye and Liu, 2024) and socialization (Cai *et al.*, 2020). We attend to a dyadic context in which we examine the impact of managers' information disclosures on social media on their subordinates. Subordinates can learn about and associate themselves with their managers via information disclosed by their managers. Despite social media being an outlet for casual information sharing, information disclosed by managers may have implications for work relationships and subordinate work activities. To delineate these potential implications, we propose to differentiate two categories of information—*work-related* and *life-related* information—that managers may disclose on social media, which has not been distinguished by previous studies on the impact of managers' social media posts.

Work-related information features information about work peers, environments, events and routines. Life-related information consists of information about personal matters. The two types of information may be conveyed in one social media post, which may feature text, vocals, visuals or any combination of these forms. Social media posts vary in nature. They may communicate positive, negative or neutral sentiments (Gaspar *et al.*, 2016; Stieglitz and Dang-Xuan, 2013). Examples of posi-

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tive work-related information disclosure include sharing professional achievements, recognitions and awards received for work, teamwork and collaborative activities, positive work environments and work opportunities. Examples of positive life-related information disclosure include sharing travel plans, personal hobbies and interests, leisure activities and family gatherings.

Our research focuses on subordinate *reactions* to manager information disclosure rather than the content of the information per se. Whether subordinates see a manager's social media post as more positive or negative and more work- or life-related is subject to subordinate interpretations. To facilitate theoretical succinctness and development, we use seemingly categorical terms (i.e. positive and negative; work-related and life-related) when conceptualizing information disclosure. However, the reality is that a piece of information can simultaneously contain both positive and negative (e.g. an opportunity for job promotion in a rural area is released) and work-related and life-related elements (e.g. a picture depicting accompanying one's children at home while working remotely). Along with a subordinate-centric view on manager information disclosure, our conceptualizations of manager positive work-related and life-related information disclosures are therefore interpreted along a continuum rather than as discrete categories.

### *Manager positive work- and life-related information disclosures and subordinate proactive behaviour and manager–subordinate relationship*

Previous studies have argued that social media could affect employee performance or work relationships as outcomes of social media information disclosures (Cui *et al.*, 2020; Gibson, 2018; Rothbard *et al.*, 2022; Wang, Yuan and Feng, 2022). We propose that manager positive work-related information disclosure on social media increases subordinate organizational identification, which subsequently increases proactive behaviour. Organizational identification refers to the degree to which individuals define themselves in relation to their organization (Ashforth, Harrison and Corley, 2008). Employees with high organizational identification tend to highly include their organization in their self-concepts (Kreiner and Ashforth, 2004) and have less intention to turnover (Smith *et al.*, 2012). Organizational identification is related to work engagement (Karanika-Murray *et al.*, 2015) and has long been suggested as an essential element of organizational success (Edwards, 2005).

Research has found that perceiving positive information about the organization, such as organizational image (Fuller *et al.*, 2006) and performance (Carmeli, Gilat and Weisberg, 2006), enhances employee organizational identification. A potential explanation is that perceiving positive information about the organization enhances employees' confidence and passion in their work (Riketta, 2005; van Dick, 2001; Walden, Jung and Westerman, 2017). Information communicated by managers serves as an important cue for subordinates to understand the organizational environment. Based on the tenets of social information processing theory, subordinates perceive and interpret cues provided by their manager to derive self-meanings in relation to the organization (Ou *et al.*, 2014). Manager posting on social media is conducive to disseminating positive work-related information to subordinates. This helps subordinates access information related to subordinates' jobs and the organization, and hence increases subordinate organization identification. In addition, manager display of positive work-related information on social media may orient subordinate attention to the positive elements or outcomes of the organization, facilitating subordinate association with and attachment to the organization.

High levels of subordinate organization identification are likely to increase subordinate proactive behaviour. Proactive behaviour is a self-starting, future-oriented act aimed to bring about constructive changes to work (Griffin, Neal and Parker, 2007). Subordinates identifying with their organization tend to integrate their organization's values and goals into their self-concepts (Riketta, 2005). They are willing to explore ways and exert efforts to contribute to organizational development, which facilitates their proactive behaviours (Crant, 2000). In support of this contention, research has suggested that individual positive attitudes towards or commitment to the organization (Brosi, Spörrle and Welpe, 2018; Fritz and Sonnentag, 2009), both of which are highly related to organizational identification (Dutton, Dukerich and Harquail, 1994), stimulate subordinate proactive behaviours, such as organizational citizenship behaviour (Cropanzano, Rupp and Byrne, 2003) and voice (see Klaas, Olson-Buchanan and Ward, 2012 for a review). Research has indeed found that organizational identification increases proactive behaviour (Wu *et al.*, 2016). Based on the above diagnosis, we propose the following hypothesis:

**H1.** *Manager positive work-related information disclosure on social media has a positive effect on subordinate proactive behaviour through subordinate organizational identification.*

We next propose that manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media promotes manager–subordinate relationship through perceived manager friendliness, which refers to regarding manager as approachable and easy-going (Crouch and Yetton, 1988). Research has contended that disclosing personal information can change work relationships (Gibson, 2018) and found that social media use for vertical communication can enhance the relationship quality between managers and subordinates (Chen and Wei,

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2020). Theories on self-disclosure elucidate that people revealing intimate information about themselves trigger liking due to being considered making efforts to build intimacy (Collins and Miller, 1994). Befriending subordinates on social media blurs hierarchical boundaries (Rothbard *et al.*, 2022) and can be done through sharing positive life-related information (Utz, 2015). When subordinates see their manager, for example, posting enjoying holidays with family members on social media, subordinates are likely to see these posts as manifestations of approachability and relationship building and hence regard their manager as friendly.

Perceived manager friendliness is likely to facilitate manager–subordinate relationship. Manager–subordinate relationship can be evaluated against the quality of social exchange between a manager and a subordinate (Cropanzano *et al.*, 2017). Perceiving manager friendliness fosters trust in, affection for, and communication with the manager, all of which are common representations of high social exchange (Cropanzano and Mitchell, 2005). Prior research has indeed shown a positive relationship between subordinates' contact with their manager and their experiences of manager friendliness (Crouch and Yetton, 1988). China's high-power distance culture (Hofstede and Bond, 1984) could make exploring the influence of manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media particularly intriguing. In such culture where managers tend to maintain distance with subordinates, positive life disclosure on social media may serve as an unconventional yet effective relational tactic. Based on the above theorization, we posit the following hypothesis:

**H2.** *Manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media has a positive effect on manager–subordinate relationship through perceived manager friendliness.*

*Moderating role of subordinate attention to social media*

Social information processing theory suggests that attention to information affects people's interest in the information and thus the extent to which they react to the information (Gurbin, 2015). This highlights the importance of subordinate attention to social media in affecting our proposed effects of managers' social media posts. Attention to social media is defined as awareness of and engagement with content shared by others on social media (Vraga, Bode and Troller-Renfree, 2016). When individuals pay more attention to social media, they are more likely to spend time browsing information on social media and construct the meaning of the social media posts. Greater subordinate attention to social media increases subordinate accessibility to manager positive information disclosures. The information disclosed becomes more salient and available for retrieval and usage (Higgins and King, 1981; Wyer and Srull, 1986). As such, the implications of manager positive work- and life-related information disclosures on social media for subordinate organizational identification and perceived manager friendliness, respectively, are likely to be stronger. Combining these arguments with those for Hypotheses 1 and 2, we postulate the following moderated mediation hypotheses:

**H3a.** *Subordinate attention to social media moderates the positive relationship between manager positive work-related information disclosure on social media and subordinate proactive behaviour through subordinate organizational identification, such that the indirect relationship is stronger when subordinate attention to social media is higher than lower.*

**H3b.** *Subordinate attention to social media moderates the positive relationship between manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media and manager–subordinate relationship through perceived manager friendliness, such that the indirect relationship is stronger when subordinate attention to social media is higher than lower.*

## Overview of studies

We conducted an experiment (i.e. pilot study) and a field survey (i.e. main study). We focus on subordinate reactions to managers' social media posts. Firstly, differentiating between social media posts and establishing causal effects of social media posts on subordinate organizational identification and perceived manager friendliness are important. The experiment features a controlled setting, which helps differentiate constructs and derive highly robust causality results (Shadish, Cook and Campbell, 2002). After establishing result internal validity, we seek to establish result external validity, which can be achieved through field surveys. In the main study, we sampled employees in real work contexts. A combination of a controlled experiment and a real-world survey helps ensure that our findings are both theoretically rigorous and practically relevant.

## Pilot study method

*Participants and procedures*

We recruited 180 employees using Credamo, a data-collection service provider in China used by prior studies (e.g. Duan *et al.*, 2024; Hu *et al.*, 2025). Among the

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participants, 40% self-identified as women, 83% had obtained a bachelor's degree, 34% were working in the manufacturing industry, 26% were working in the information technology industry, and 13% were working in the finance industry. Participants' average age was 31.51 (standard deviation [SD] = 8.07) years. Participants were compensated with five Chinese Yuan for their participation in the study.

Participants were asked to imagine that they were employees of a company. Their direct manager was Liu. To control for the potential confounding influence of manager competence, we described Liu as an average competent manager in the organization. Then, participants were randomly assigned to one of the three conditions (i.e. manager work-related information disclosure, manager life-related information disclosure and manager mixed information disclosure[1]). Each condition had 60 participants. Participants were told that they saw a post by Liu on Liu's WeChat Moment. Participants in the work-related information disclosure condition saw a post that contained information about work only. Participants in the life-related information disclosure condition saw a post that contained information about life only. Participants in the mixed information disclosure condition saw a post that contained information about both work and life. The posts are presented in Appendix A in the Supporting Information.

### *Measures*

After seeing Liu's social media posts, we asked participants to assess their identification with the organization in the scenario and Liu's friendliness. We used a five-item measurement (Smidts, Pruyn and van Riel, 2001) to measure organizational identification. A sample item is, 'I experience a strong sense of belonging to this organization' (1 = *strongly disagree* to 5 = *strongly agree*; Cronbach's alpha [$\alpha$] = 0.88). We used a five-item measurement (Zapata and Hayes-Jones, 2019) to measure manager friendliness. Participants were asked to evaluate the extent to which Liu is seen as *warm*, *helpful*, *cooperative*, *amiable*, and *genuine* (1 = *strongly disagree* to 5 = *strongly agree*; $\alpha = 0.89$). Then, we conducted manipulation check using two items ('Liu's post is related to work' and 'Liu's post is related to life'; 1 = *strongly disagree* to 5 = *strongly agree*).

[1]According to an anonymous reviewer, although we focus on the effects of manager positive work- and life-related information disclosures on social media, managers could simultaneously disclose positive work- and life-related information in one social media post. As such, we considered a mixed condition.

## Pilot study results

The means of the focal variables in each condition are shown in Table 1. The ANOVA results show that participants' ratings on work-related information ($F = 395.65$, $p < 0.001$) and life-related information ($F = 183.18$, $p < 0.001$) significantly differed among the three conditions. Participants in the work-related information disclosure condition ($\text{Mean}_{\text{difference}} = 3.28$, $t = 25.83$, $p < 0.001$) and the mixed information disclosure condition ($\text{Mean}_{\text{difference}} = 2.87$, $t = 22.56$, $p < 0.001$) evaluated the social media post to contain more work-related than life-related information. Participants in the life-related information disclosure condition ($\text{Mean}_{\text{difference}} = 2.70$, $t = 18.37$, $p < 0.001$) and the mixed information disclosure condition ($\text{Mean}_{\text{difference}} = 2.03$, $t = 13.84$, $p < 0.001$) evaluated the social media post to contain more life-related than work-related information.

Participants' ratings on organizational identification ($F = 8.77$, $p < 0.001$) and perceived manager friendliness ($F = 32.84$, $p < 0.001$) significantly differed among the three conditions. Compared with participants in the life-related information disclosure condition, those in the work-related information disclosure condition ($\text{Mean}_{\text{difference}} = 0.35$, $t = 2.68$, $p < 0.05$) and the mixed information disclosure condition ($\text{Mean}_{\text{difference}} = 0.54$, $t = 4.13$, $p < 0.001$) reported higher organizational identification. Compared with participants in the work-related information disclosure condition, those in the life-related information disclosure condition ($\text{Mean}_{\text{difference}} = 0.88$, $t = 7.29$, $p < 0.01$) and the mixed information disclosure condition ($\text{Mean}_{\text{difference}} = 0.81$, $t = 6.72$, $p < 0.01$) reported higher perceived manager friendliness. These experimental results not only suggest manipulation validity (i.e. participants can differentiate types of information disclosures) but also help establish the causal effects of manager positive work- and life-related information disclosures on subordinate organizational identification and perceived manager friendliness, respectively.

## Main study method

### *Participants and procedures*

Three-wave data were collected through the alumni networks of several universities in China. A total of 244 full-time employees, who had managers to report to, participated in the survey. Participants were informed about the research purpose, participation voluntariness and response confidentiality. We sent questionnaire links to the participants through WeChat. As a 1-month lag helps reduce common method bias (Ostroff, Kinicki and Clark, 2002), questionnaires were sent at three time points, each separated by 1 month. We used participants' WeChat ID to match their responses across the

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*Table 1. Means of focal variables in each condition in the pilot study*

| Conditions | Work-related information disclosure manipulation check | Life-related information disclosure manipulation check | Organizational identification | Perceived manager friendliness |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Work-related information disclosure condition ($n = 60$) | 4.63 | 2.05 | 4.20 | 3.50 |
| Life-related information disclosure condition ($n = 60$) | 1.35 | 4.75 | 3.85 | 4.39 |
| Mixed information disclosure condition ($n = 60$) | 4.22 | 4.08 | 4.39 | 4.32 |

three times (Qin, Wang and Li, 2020). Each WeChat ID was allowed to submit only one set of responses for each questionnaire. All participants had added their line manager as a friend on WeChat and could see their line manager's WeChat posts. At Time 1, 244 participants reported on their attention to social media and their manager's positive work- and life-related information disclosures on social media. At Time 2 (1 month later), 238 participants reported on their organizational identification and perceived manager friendliness. At Time 3 (2 months after Time 1), 225 participants evaluated their proactive behaviour and relationship with their line manager. To reduce sample attrition, participants were compensated with 10 Chinese Yuan upon completion of each questionnaire. The final sample consists of 211 employees who filled in the questionnaire at all three time points. Their average age and working tenure with their line manager were 27.55 (SD = 4.86) years and 2.55 (SD = 2.08) years, respectively. Many self-identified as women (63%). Participants worked in various industries, including information technology (31%), manufacturing (30%) and services (18%).

### *Measures*

We followed standard translation and back-translation procedures to generate the survey items in Chinese (Brislin, 1986). Specifically, one academic translated the original English measurements to Chinese. Another academic translated them back to English. We reconciled the translation differences by discussing them with a third academic. Unless otherwise specified, all measures were rated on a five-point Likert-type scale ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*).

Based on research on work and life social media usage (e.g. Gonzalez *et al.*, 2013), we measured *manager positive work- and life-related information disclosures on social media* with six items ($\alpha = 0.87$) and five items ($\alpha = 0.91$), respectively. We specified WeChat as the social medium. As there is no readily available measure for *attention to social media* to our knowledge, we developed a three-item measure. We first drew from the social media (e.g. Holt *et al.*, 2013; Vraga, Bode and Troller-Renfree, 2016) and information processing (e.g. Fulk *et al.*, 1987) literatures to generate three items. Then, we recruited 11 subject matter experts (7 professors and 4 doctoral candidates in organizational behaviour) to assess the extent to which these items matched the construct definition on a five-point scale ranging from 1 (*Item is an extremely bad match*) to 5 (*Item is an extremely good match*). The mean score is 4.24 ($\alpha = 0.86$), which is consistent with other studies using this procedure (average ratings greater than 4.0; Rodell, 2013). *Organizational identification* was measured by five items ($\alpha = 0.89$; Smidts, Pruyn and van Riel, 2001). *Perceived manager friendliness* was measured by five items ($\alpha = 0.89$; Zapata and Hayes-Jones, 2019). *Proactive behaviour* was measured by three items ($\alpha = 0.87$; Griffin, Neal and Parker, 2007). *Manager–subordinate relationship* was measured by seven items ($\alpha = 0.86$; Scandura and Graen, 1984). These measurements are presented in Appendix B in the Supporting Information.

We *controlled* for participants' age, gender and tenure with manager owing to their potential influences on individuals' work behaviours (Ng and Feldman, 2010) and relationships with important others (Farh *et al.*, 1998). We controlled for participants' social media usage due to its potential influence on awareness of managers' information disclosures on social media and participants' attitude towards social media (Chen and Wei, 2020; Yang, 2020). Social media usage was measured by three items (Yang, 2020). A sample item is 'I often use social media' ($\alpha = 0.78$).

## Main study results

### *Measurement validity and reliability*

Following existing procedures and statistical recommendations (Spector, 2019), we minimized common method bias by assuring participants about response confidentiality and using reverse items. The results of Harman's one-factor test show that no single variable explains a majority of the variance (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003). We examined nonresponse bias. The results show that there are no significant differences in age, gender, and work tenure between those responded and those did not ($0.10 < F < 0.40$, $0.53 < p < 0.91$).

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*Table 2. Means, standard deviations, intercorrelations and internal consistencies in the main study*

| Variables | Mean | SD | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 | 11 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Age | 27.55 | 4.86 | — | | | | | | | | | | |
| 2. Gender | 1.63 | 0.49 | −0.23 | — | | | | | | | | | |
| 3. Tenure with manager | 2.55 | 2.08 | 0.48 | −0.27 | — | | | | | | | | |
| 4. Subordinate social media usage | 3.01 | 0.87 | 0.05 | 0.02 | 0.15* | (0.78) | | | | | | | |
| 5. Manager positive work-related information disclosure on social media | 3.55 | 0.84 | −0.02 | 0.02 | 0.02 | 0.48** | (0.87) | | | | | | |
| 6. Manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media | 3.67 | 0.87 | 0.09 | −0.05 | 0.15* | 0.44** | 0.44** | (0.91) | | | | | |
| 7. Subordinate attention to social media | 3.69 | 0.78 | 0.09 | −0.00 | 0.17* | 0.49** | 0.36** | 0.46** | (0.86) | | | | |
| 8. Subordinate organizational identification | 3.79 | 0.65 | 0.22** | −0.13 | 0.24* | 0.35** | 0.45** | 0.32** | 0.27** | (0.89) | | | |
| 9. Perceived manager friendliness | 3.85 | 0.64 | 0.11 | 0.02 | 0.13* | 0.28** | 0.23** | 0.29** | 0.26** | 0.59** | (0.89) | | |
| 10. Subordinate proactive behaviour | 3.77 | 0.66 | 0.27** | 0.10 | 0.16* | 0.29** | 0.35** | 0.35** | 0.29** | 0.50** | 0.37** | (0.87) | |
| 11. Manager–subordinate relationship | 3.46 | 0.66 | 0.12 | −0.09 | 0.26** | 0.29** | 0.33** | 0.32** | 0.26** | 0.54** | 0.59** | 0.46** | (0.86) |

*Note*: $N = 211$. SD = standard deviation. Cronbach's alphas are presented in parentheses. Gender: 1 = male, 2 = female.
$^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$.

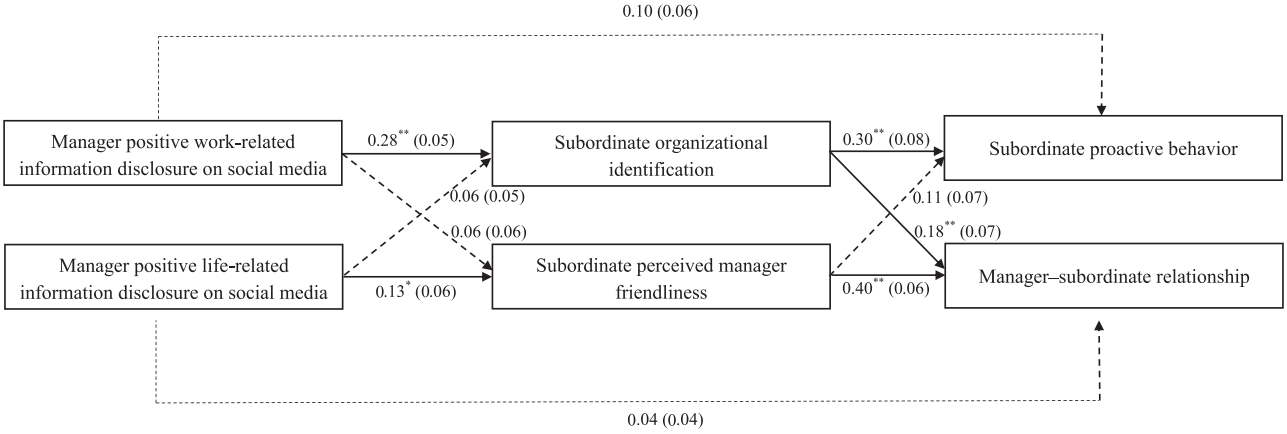



*Figure 1. Path-analytic indirect effect results in the main study. N = 211. Unstandardized coefficient estimates are reported. Values in parentheses are standard errors. Significant relationships are depicted by solid lines. To ensure presentation clarity, coefficient estimates associated with the control variables are not presented.* $^{*}$ *p < 0.05,* $^{**}$ *p < 0.01.*

We conducted confirmatory factor analysis to test the discriminant validity of the measures. The hypothesized seven-factor model demonstrates good fit (chi-square [$\chi^2$] = 815.06, degrees of freedom [df] = 506, $p < 0.01$, standardized root mean square residual = 0.05, root mean square error of approximation = 0.05, comparative fit index = 0.93, Tuck–Lewis index = 0.92) and significant change in $\chi^2$ relative to change in df (i.e. $\Delta\chi^2$ [$\Delta$df]) when compared with some other alternative models (proactive behaviour and manager–subordinate relationship combined: $\Delta\chi^2$ [$\Delta$df] = 237.84 [6], $p < 0.01$; organizational identification and perceived manager friendliness combined: $\Delta\chi^2$ [$\Delta$df] = 258.85 [6], $p < 0.01$; manager positive work-related information and life-related information disclosures combined: $\Delta\chi^2$ [$\Delta$df] = 414.53 [6], $p < 0.01$). The factor loadings of the hypothesized model and Cronbach's alpha of each factor are shown in Appendix C in the Supporting Information. We calculated the variance inflation factors to test for multicollinearity. The results reveal that the variance inflation factors of the focal variables are below 4, suggesting that multicollinearity is not a significant issue. Altogether, these results provide sufficient evidence for the validity and reliability of our theoretical model.

### *Hypothesis tests*

The descriptive statistics and intercorrelations are presented in Table 2. We conducted path analysis using Mplus 7.4 (Muthén and Muthén, 1998–2017) to test the hypotheses. All continuous predictors were grand-mean centred to decrease multicollinearity (Cohen, West and Aiken, 2003). The path analysis results of the mediation model and the moderated mediation model are presented in Figures 1 and 2, respectively. We used the Monte Carlo simulation (with 20,000 repetitions; Preacher and Selig, 2012) to test for indirect effect (Bauer, Preacher and Gil, 2006).

As presented in Figure 1, manager positive work-related information disclosure on social media is pos-

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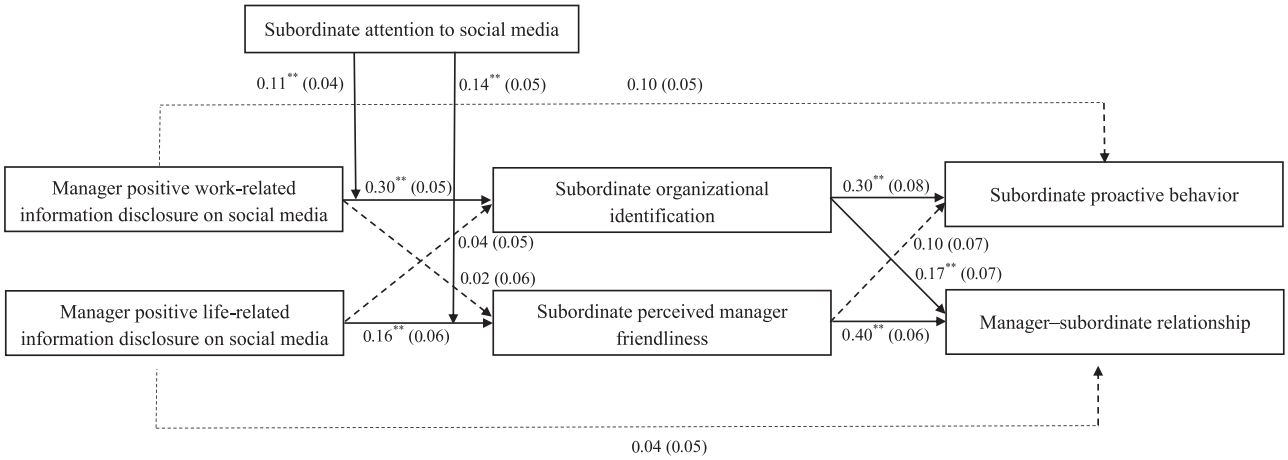



*Figure 2. Path-analytic conditional indirect effect results in the main study. N = 211. Unstandardized coefficient estimates are reported. Values in parentheses are standard errors. Significant relationships are depicted by solid lines. To ensure presentation clarity, coefficient estimates associated with the control variables are not presented.* $^{*}$ *p < 0.05,* $^{**}$ *p < 0.01.*

itively related to subordinate organizational identification (unstandardized regression coefficient estimate [*B*] = 0.28, standard error [SE] = 0.05, $p < 0.01$). Subordinate organizational identification is positively related to subordinate proactive behaviour ($B = 0.30$, SE = 0.08, $p < 0.01$). The results of the Monte Carlo simulation indicate that the positive effect of manager positive work-related information disclosure on subordinate proactive behaviour through subordinate organizational identification is significant ($B_{\text{indirect effect}} = 0.08$, Monte Carlo 95% confidence interval [CI] = 0.03, 0.14). Therefore, Hypothesis 1 is supported.

Manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media is positively related to perceived manager friendliness ($B = 0.13$, SE = 0.06, $p < 0.05$). Perceived manager friendliness is positively associated with manager–subordinate relationship ($B = 0.40$, SE = 0.06, $p < 0.01$). Hypothesis 2 is supported, as the positive effect of manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media on manager–subordinate relationship through perceived manager friendliness is significant ($B_{\text{indirect effect}} = 0.05$, Monte Carlo 95% CI = 0.01, 0.10).

As illustrated by Figure 2, the interaction between manager positive work-related information disclosure on social media and subordinate attention to social media is positively related to subordinate organizational identification ($B = 0.11$, SE = 0.04, $p < 0.01$). This interactive effect is plotted in Figure 3. The positive relationship between manager positive work-related information disclosure on social media and subordinate proactive behaviour through subordinate organizational identification is more positive when subordinate attention to social media is 'high' (i.e. one SD above the mean; $B_{\text{indirect effect}} = 0.12$, Monte Carlo 95% CI = 0.04, 0.19) than 'low' (i.e. one SD below the mean; $B_{\text{indirect effect}} = 0.07$, Monte Carlo 95% CI = 0.02, 0.12; $B_{\text{difference}} = 0.05$, Monte Carlo 95% CI = 0.002, 0.10). These results support Hypothesis 3a.

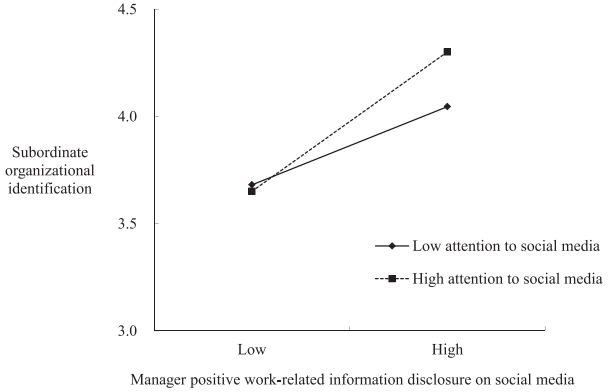



*Figure 3. Moderating role of subordinate attention to social media on the relationship between manager positive work-related information disclosure on social media and subordinate organizational identification in the main study.*

The interaction between manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media and subordinate attention to social media is positively related to perceived manager friendliness ($B = 0.14$, SE = 0.05, $p < 0.01$). This interactive effect is presented in Figure 4. The positive effect of manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media on manager–subordinate relationship through perceived manager friendliness is more positive when subordinate attention to social media is 'high' ($B_{\text{indirect effect}} = 0.11$, Monte Carlo 95% CI = 0.04, 0.18) than 'low' ($B_{\text{indirect effect}} = 0.02$, Monte Carlo 95% CI = −0.03, 0.07; $B_{\text{difference}} = 0.09$, Monte Carlo 95% CI = 0.02, 0.15). These results confirm Hypothesis 3b. All hypotheses remain supported when the control variables are excluded from the path analyses.

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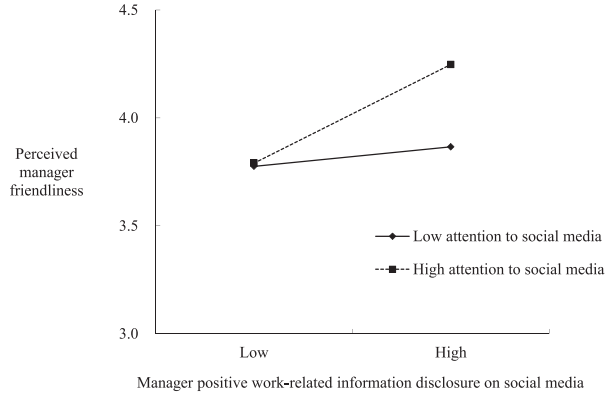



*Figure 4. Moderating role of subordinate attention to social media on the relationship between manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media and perceived manager friendliness in the main study.*

## Discussion

We found that manager positive work-related information disclosure on social media increased subordinate proactive behaviour through subordinate organizational identification, and that manager positive life-related information disclosure on social media facilitated manager–subordinate relationship through perceived manager friendliness. Greater subordinate attention to social media strengthened the positive effects of manager information disclosures on social media. Contributions to the existing literature, insights for practice, and study limitations and directions for future research are discussed in the following sections.

### *Theoretical implications*

We advance the managerial influence research via a phenomenon-centric approach (McNamara and Schleicher, 2024). Our research represents an intersection of social media use and managerial influences. Social media has become an integral part of many people's lives, making its usage a prominent research topic. *Managers* should not be equated with *leaders*, especially in social media contexts. Public leaders, such as politicians, celebrities, opinion leaders and high-profile C-suite organizational personnel, have large followership and can garner much attention and publicity on social media. Unlike followers of public leaders who more often than not rely on social media to acquire information about them, employees can acquire information from their direct manager via multiple channels (e.g. face-to-face interactions), therefore potentially diminishing the impact of managers' social media posts on them. This raises questions on whether managers' social media posts can influence subordinates and, if so, in what ways.

We focus on manager–subordinate contexts and are at the forefront of distinguishing between manager work-related and life-related information disclosures. Studies have examined the common types of information people share on social media. For instance, Tan and Goh (2015) categorized social media information into recommendations, events, friends and media elements, whereas Oh and Syn (2015) divided it into informational, social support and entertainment-related. We offer nuanced categories of information disclosures on social media. We also delineate two separate influence mechanisms through which managers' social media posts affect subordinates. Our findings highlight that manager positive *work-related* information disclosure triggers a *work* influence mechanism and that manager positive *life-related* information disclosure stimulates a *relationship* influence mechanism.

Subordinates' dyadic relationship with their manager is personal. Studies have primarily investigated the development of manager–subordinate relationships from a social exchange perspective (Cropanzano and Mitchell, 2005), which suggests that the socioemotional support provided by managers facilitates managers' affiliation with subordinates (Wilson, Sin and Conlon, 2010). Managers' personal life disclosures, based on social information processing arguments, can be interpreted as socioemotional cues. However, our findings on strengthened friendliness perceptions and relationships may not apply to followers of public leaders owing to their limited capacity to develop personal relationships with those public leaders. This could potentially explain why Yue *et al.* (2021) did not find that CEOs' personal disclosures enhance adult Twitter users' perceived likability of CEOs. As such, strengthened friendliness perceptions and relationships due to positive self-disclosure on social media may be more associated with more proximal work colleagues (e.g. managers; Rothbard *et al.*, 2022) than non–direct-contact individuals (e.g. public leaders).

In addition, according to social information processing theory, line managers are likely to have a more direct and significant impact on employees' work attitudes and behaviours (Ou *et al.*, 2014). Public leaders external to the organization within which followers work may not be able to facilitate desirable work-related outcomes for followers' organizations, even if followers identify with those public leaders interpersonally. Organizational identification can be stimulated by influences from people within the same organization (e.g. supervisors; He and Brown, 2013) but not likely by people external to the organization. In short, there may exist other responses from followers to processing both work and personal information disclosed by public leaders than the ones found in our research on subordinates' processing of direct managers' information disclosures.

Furthermore, the characteristics of information receivers can influence how information is perceived and interpreted (Gundlach, Douglas and Martinko, 2003).

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Complementing research that focused on employees' social media usage time and frequency (Pekkala and van Zoonen, 2022), we revealed the important role of attention to social media in moderating subordinates' responses to managers' information disclosures on social media. Interestingly, based on the interaction patterns shown in Figures 3 and 4, the extent to which managers' positive life-related social media posts lead to perceived manager friendliness is more affected by the degree to which subordinates attend to social media than the extent to which managers' positive work-related social media posts lead to subordinate organizational identification. This finding highlights that contextual influences should especially be considered when examining the relationship between disclosing personal information and others' perceptions about the focal individual (Rothbard *et al.*, 2022).

Our findings may also add to knowledge about Chinese employees' work patterns and sensitivity to work information in relation to social media usage. WeChat is generally considered a socialization-oriented social medium (Song *et al.*, 2019). The fact that our findings show that managers posting work-related information on WeChat can trigger desirable work reactions from subordinates suggests that many Chinese employees may have accepted a non–work-oriented social medium as an information source for work activities.

### *Practical implications*

Our findings suggest that social media can be used not only for leisure but also for facilitating desired work outcomes. We encourage managers to use social media to potentially influence subordinates in both task- and work-relationship–related aspects. By leveraging the functionality of social media for organizational ambassadorship (van Zoonen, van der Meer and Verhoeven, 2014), managers engaging in positive work-related information disclosures on social media, such as posting positive messages about the organization and their team, may increase subordinates' organizational identification and proactive behaviour. Managers could also use social media to elicit friendliness perceptions and strengthen their relationships with their subordinates by sharing positive aspects of their personal life on social media. We encourage managers to interact with their subordinates on social media to increase their likelihood of being attended to by subordinates on social media.

### *Limitations and future research directions*

We focused on information communicated by managers' social media posts rather than the nature of the posts (e.g. text, vocals and visuals). We acknowledge that the strength of the message communicated may vary among types of posts (e.g. 'a picture may worth a thousand words'; Li and Xie, 2020). Social media posts containing images may be catchier and draw more attention than posts containing text only (Pieters and Wedel, 2004). As such, conveying the same piece of information to employees through different types and combinations of content may impact employees' perceptions about and reactions to the posts differently.

Managers may use social media as a means to manage their impressions. We found that manager positive work- and life-related information disclosures on social media elicited subordinate organizational identification and perceived manager friendliness, respectively. However, if subordinates were to deem these information disclosures as managers' impression management efforts, they may react differently. Moreover, if subordinates' relationships with their manager are suboptimal or subordinates are under high stress, seeing their manager's positive information disclosures on social media may lead to increased aversion towards the manager. Future studies could investigate the potential negative impact of managers' social media usage on subordinates.

Besides positive information disclosures, future research can also attend to manager negative information disclosures on social media. Although disclosing negative information about the organization (e.g. organizational scandals) may seem 'politically incorrect' from an organizational standpoint, managers doing so may be considered transparent and trustworthy. In addition, tracking managers' social media posts over a period of time can render a more holistic picture of managers' positive, negative and neutral posts and hence subordinates' reactions to these posts.

Despite a multi-wave survey design, we cannot draw definitive causal conclusions on the hypothesized relationships nor can we completely rule out reverse causality. For instance, managers may be more willing to disclose their work and personal lives to their subordinates after they have established stronger relationships with their subordinates or their subordinates are more active in commenting on their social media posts. Conducting longitudinal studies not only can better test for causality but also can capture fluctuations in subordinates' responses to manager information disclosures on social media over time. In addition to WeChat, managers may post on other social media platforms.

Research has shown that individual characteristics, such as gender, age, cultural values, extraversion and social comparison orientation, may influence perceptions about social media information (Deng, Fernández and Zhao, 2022; Pasko and Arigo, 2021; Stahl and Literat, 2023). For example, generally, women may be more sensitive to perceived emotional instances (Snodgrass, 1992) and more likely to search for information from profiles on social networking sites than men (Krasnova *et al.*, 2017), which could lead to female subordinates

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resonating more with certain managers' social media posts. Whereas more men participated in the pilot study, more women participated in the main study. This random gender distribution enhances our findings' robustness. In addition, our main study participants were relatively young. Younger generations may be more welcoming and acceptive of social media (Stahl and Literat, 2023) owing to more frequent social media use and more attention to information on social media. Future research could add to our research by incorporating employee demographic characteristics in theorization.

Lastly, both the pilot study and the main study were conducted in a Chinese setting. Employees in a high-power-distance Chinese culture may feel a higher obligation to conform with managers and respond to managers in ways that conform to managers' expectations. They may also place greater emphasis on belongingness (Saad, Cleveland and Ho, 2015) and are more concerned with their colleagues' attitudes and behaviours (Voronov and Singer, 2002). We encourage future studies to examine our results' generalizability by drawing on samples from other contexts. We hope our work stimulates further research, ultimately contributing to a more comprehensive understanding of the complex dynamics between managers' social media usage and subordinate proactive behaviour and manager–subordinate relationship.

## Conflict of interest statement

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

### *Data availability statement*

The data used in this research can be obtained upon request from the corresponding author.

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Shengming Liu is an Associate Professor at School of Management, Fudan University. His research interests focus on leadership, social media and new technologies in organization. He has published in *Journal of Applied Psychology*, *Journal of Management* and *Journal of Management Studies*.

Jih-Yu Mao is a Professor at Nottingham University Business School China, University of Nottingham Ningbo China. He is interested in creativity, territoriality and social media use in the workplace. His scholarly output has appeared in *Organization Science*, *Journal of Management*, *Journal of Organizational Behavior* and *Journal of Management Studies*.

Zhang Yue is currently a PhD candidate at School of Management, Fudan University. Her research interests mainly revolve around sustainability, leadership and corporate social responsibility, with a particular focus on how sustainable strategies and strategic leadership influence corporate social responsibility performance.

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Maoyu Zhang is an Assistant Professor at Tongji University. Her research interests include career development and social media. She has published in *Career Development International*.

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